



Delaware County Council Meeting March 29th 2022

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fguklZQ8LFU
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Delaware County Council Meeting Summary

Meeting Date: March 29, 2022

Location: Delaware County Commissioners Courtroom

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order:** Presiding officer Emily called the Delaware County Council meeting to order at [00:00:42](#). Members and attendees stood for the Pledge of Allegiance led by Tony.
- **Attendance:**
 - **Present:** Mr. Ballard, Ms. Chambers, Ms. Lassiter (online), Ms. Piper, Mr. Quakenbush, Mr. Webb, Mr. Alexander, and Mr. Freeman.
 - **Absent:** None noted.

3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** Opening Pledge of Allegiance led by Tony.
- **Approval of Agenda:** The agenda was confirmed as posted and advertised. Approved by roll call vote (All in favor).
- **Approval of Minutes:** Disposition of the February minutes was approved following a motion by Ms. Piper and a second by Mr. Ballard. Passed by roll call vote.

4. Substantive Business & Board Action

- **00:04:09 Judge Wolf <U+2013> Circuit Court Magistrate Position Proposal**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Judge Linda Raylou Wolf (Delaware Circuit Court No. 3, presiding judge of Delaware Circuit Courts) alongside Emily Anderson, Court Administrator.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Judge Wolf requested council support to transition the current master commissioner position into a state-funded magistrate position. The process requires county council approval, followed by letters of support from commissioners, the prosecutor, and the bar association, before submission to the state legislative study committee. While the county will remain responsible for a portion of the salary (\$35,314.20 total cost across budgets), the change will free up approximately \$42,000 annually in the court budget, absorb benefits through the state, and greatly improve legal efficiency by allowing the magistrate to sign binding orders directly instead of submitting recommendations for judicial review.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Council expressed general support and agreed to place a formal letter of approval on the agenda for the next month's meeting.
- **00:29:51 Financial Transfers & Budget Adjustments**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Presented by Donna/Tanya.
 - **Deliberation Summary:**
 - *Public Defender:* Transfer of \$25,000 to hire two new public defenders following resignations.
 - *Sheriff's Office:* Transfer of \$3,000 to cover a delayed December bonus settlement payment.
 - *Correctional Officer / Jail:* Transfers (~\$28,070.76 and separate adjustments) to cover staffing and late December payouts/settlement wages.
 - *Highway Department (MVH):* Internal transfers (\$34,157.08, \$35,987.80, and \$36,071.48) reflecting truck driver and equipment operator personnel replacements.
 - *Title IV-D Court:* \$229 for life insurance increases.
 - *EDIT Projects:* \$4,000,000 appropriation (noting ~\$3.614 million goes directly toward annual bond payments).
 - *Cumulative Building (Key Fobs):* \$175 for door security key fobs.
 - *Convention and Tourism (Visitors Bureau):* \$36,000 transfer from reserves to operating to hire a nationwide search firm (*Searchwide*) for a new executive director after an initial local search failed.
 - *CASA & CASA JCAT / Family Recovery Court Grant:* Minor life/health insurance adjustments (\$195, \$265, and \$188).

- *Adult User Fee*: \$12,833 for health and life insurance due to staffing changes requiring benefits.
- *Sales Disclosure Fund*: \$1,273 for postcard printing and annual dues/subscriptions.
- *Statewide 911*: \$100,000 for PSAP equipment (radio console/electronics) and \$33,000 to cover delayed December union grievance settlement payments for 11 former employees.
- **Item-Specific Public Input**: Jared Walls (Visitors Bureau) answered council questions regarding the \$36,000 executive director search contract, confirming it covers all search-related expenses and includes a 1-year placement guarantee.
- **Action & Vote Disposition**: All financial transfers, salary ordinance amendments, and hiring freeze adjustments were **Approved by Roll Call Vote** (Passed unanimously).

5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- **01:08:42 Tim Nickum (Resident)**
 - **Topic**: Large-scale solar energy implementation and zoning ordinance updates.
 - **Key Concerns**: Requested that the county council commission an independent economic impact development study focused specifically on agricultural suppliers and service providers in Delaware County, noting that existing reports (like the Baker Tilly report) originate from solar developers. He also discussed his appointment to the upcoming 9-person solar steering committee being formed by Marta Moody.
- **01:18:58 Harold King (Gaston Area Farmer)**
 - **Topic**: Solar steering committee and county road conditions.
 - **Key Concerns**: Noted difficulties in selecting neutral members for the upcoming solar steering committee due to polarized community opinions. Additionally, he offered positive feedback praising the county highway department for doing a responsive, great job maintaining local roads during winter.

6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements**:
 - Pam McCamon (HR Director) clarified that short-term and long-term disability rates had not increased globally, but rather individual department jumps were due to employees opting into higher supplemental life insurance tiers.
 - Sheriff Tony Skinner provided a jail staffing update, noting the facility is currently about 10 positions short, though noting four recent hires moved on to local police departments as stepping stones. Overtime is at 50% utilization for the first three months of the year.

- **Adjournment:** The meeting was officially adjourned following a motion by Ms. Piper and a second by Mr. Ballard, approved by roll call vote [01:20:04](#).

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